

Introduction

State intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD) agencies use funds from Medicaid Home and Community-Based Services (HCBS) waivers to pay for employment and day services. The Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services (CMS) has clarified that individual competitive employment is the preferred outcome of employment supports offered within HCBS waivers (CMS, 2011, 2014). However, while people with IDD want to work and employers want to hire, state IDD agency funding strategies do not consistently support long-term growth in integrated employment, and state IDD agency investment in integrated employment varies widely across states (SELN, 2015; Winsor et al., 2025). How waivers are structured—through contracting methods, payment rates, and service definitions—can shape access to employment for individuals with IDD (Nord, 2020; Winsor et al., 2017).

This summary describes the third of three studies on state HCBS waivers that support people with IDD in employment and day services.

In study 1, we cataloged state IDD agency employment service contracting methods and service payment rates for each of the 50 states and the District of Columbia to describe and categorize financing policy within approved Medicaid waivers (1915c, i, j, and k) that serve individuals with IDD.

In study 2, we used the catalog to conduct quantitative analyses to identify predictive variables that lead to better employment outcomes (employment services participation used as a proxy) compared to variables from the catalog of state IDD waivers to service measures.

In study 3, we created a Delphi Panel to further clarify which waiver elements are perceived as most important to state IDD agency staff to increase integrated employment.

In this brief, we will:

- explain the Delphi process and how it was used in this study
- summarize what experts identified as the most important waiver elements for increasing employment participation
- share key considerations for policymakers and providers
- highlight next steps for research and practice

Who were the Delphi panelists?

The panel included state IDD agency staff with deep knowledge of employment services and HCBS waivers. Their perspectives reflected both policy-level and on-the-ground experience including:

- **Design:** developing waiver definitions for employment and/or day services
- **Implementation:** implementing state policy and practice guidance on employment and/or day services
- **Monitoring:** monitoring employment and day services

Nearly all indicated involvement in all three major areas of waiver oversight—design, implementation, and monitoring—reflecting a high level of expertise in state employment systems.



Expertise	Number of panelists	Example responsibilities
Developing waiver definitions for employment/ day services	6	Drafting HCBS definitions, reviewing program language, coordinating new waiver designs
Implementing state policy and practice guidance	7	Overseeing employment and day service policy rollout, collaborating with VR and Dept. of Education partners
Monitoring employment and day services	6	Tracking outcomes, provider compliance, data analysis, and rate studies
All of the above	5	Holding leadership or management roles encompassing design, implementation, and monitoring.

How was the Delphi process implemented?

We conducted a 3-round Delphi process using online surveys. In **Round 1**, experts were asked to rate 11 waiver elements identified through earlier ICI research (Shepard et al., 2025) as *essential*, *helpful but not essential*, or *not necessary* for increasing employment participation among individuals with IDD. Panelists were also given the opportunity to list any elements they thought were missing from the list. Based on their feedback, we refined and expanded the list to 14 elements for **Round 2**, where panelists completed the same rating process. By the end of the second round, consensus was evident across the set of elements. In **Round 3**, panelists shifted from rating to prioritizing, ranking all 14 elements in order of importance. To capture broader patterns in their decision-making, we also grouped the elements into five conceptual categories and asked panelists to rank these categories. In all three rounds, participants were given the opportunity to provide open-ended responses to each waiver element.

What is a Delphi process?

A Delphi process is a research technique. In the Delphi process, researchers ask multiple rounds of questions about a complex problem to individual experts. The process is anonymous to encourage each expert to come to their answers independently without influencing each other. This process embraces a range of opinions in a way that ensures that uncertainties related to the problem are accurately represented (Row & Wright, 1999).

Findings from the Delphi Panel

Top Areas of Consensus: Incentives and Skills

A central priority identified by panelists was **higher hourly reimbursement rates for supported employment**. Participants consistently ranked this above other elements, emphasizing that rates send a direct signal to providers about which services states value. Closely connected to this finding was the **importance of training requirements for staff delivering employment services and supports**. Specifically, panelists emphasized that requirements for practical, best-practice training are more essential than requirements for completing trainings that lead to specific certifications such as ACRE or APSE training. Together, these two elements emerged as the strongest points of agreement to expand employment opportunities.

Transportation

The availability of transportation services ranked in the middle of the priorities, reflecting ongoing importance, but also complexity of implementation. Panelists recognized that lack of reliable transportation remains one of the most persistent barriers to employment for people with IDD. At the same time, there was caution around simply embedding payment for transportation into employment and day service types as allowable activities. Instead, stand-alone transportation supports or those clearly tied to employment activities were viewed as the most effective strategies.

Waiver Elements	Conceptual Categories
Including the option to allow providers to bill for remotely- delivered supported employment services, when this option is chosen through the person-centered planning process and appropriate to the individual's goals	1 Including the option to allow providers to bill for remotely-delivered services, when this option is chosen through the person-centered planning process and appropriate to the individual's goals
Including the option to allow providers to bill for remotely- delivered day services, when this option is chosen through person-centered planning and appropriate to the individual's goals	
Including the option to allow providers to bill for other types of services delivered remotely, when chosen through person-centered planning and appropriate to the individual's goals	
Higher hourly rates for supported employment services (e.g., higher reimbursement per unit for delivering service)	2 Higher hourly rates for services (e.g., higher reimbursement per unit for delivering service)
Ability to use waiver funds to purchase or access assistive technology (e.g., apps, devices, connectivity) that enables individuals to benefit from remote delivery of supported employment services	3 Ability to use waiver funds to purchase or access assistive technology (e.g., apps, devices, connectivity) that enables individuals to benefit from remote delivery of services
Ability to use waiver funds to purchase or access assistive technology (e.g., apps, devices, connectivity) that enables individuals to benefit from remote delivery of day services	
Ability to use waiver funds to purchase or access assistive technology (e.g., apps, devices, connectivity) that enables individuals to benefit from remote delivery of other types of services	
Requiring training on best practices in supported employment for new employment staff	4 Requiring training, through certification or otherwise, on best practices in delivering services for new employment staff
Requiring training on how day services can lead to supported employment	
Requiring Association of Community Rehabilitation Educators (ACRE) certified training for staff who deliver supported employment service (ACRE training includes training in core competencies for employment services, including job development and supports)	
Requiring Association of People Supporting Employment First (APSE) certification for staff who deliver supported employment services (APSE certification is a national credential demonstrating knowledge of best practices in employment supports)	
Including transportation to and/or from the job within the supported employment service (e.g., reimbursed within the service rate)	5 Including transportation to and/or from service activity within the service definition
Including transportation to and/or from the provider or community activity within non-work services (e.g., reimbursed within the service rate)	
Offering transportation services as a standalone service specifically for getting to and/or from a job (not included in the rate for habilitation or other support services)	

Remote Service Delivery and Assistive Technology

Panelists placed lower emphasis overall on remote service delivery and availability of assistive technology to enhance employment services. These elements were ranked higher when they were directly connected to employment services, suggesting that panelists see them as emerging tools rather than stand-alone solutions. Both elements were described as a way to increase flexibility and reduce barriers to participation, particularly when used to actively support employment goals.

Agreement among Panelists

Panel results showed moderate but statistically significant agreement on the ordering of individual elements (Kendall's $W = 0.36$, $p < 0.001$). While there was less uniformity at the broader category level ($W = 0.28$, $p = 0.044$), this agreement was still statistically significant, suggesting that experts broadly converged on the relative importance of these elements of HCBS waivers to impact employment services.

Conclusion and Considerations

Funding incentives and staff capacity are seen as the strongest elements for increasing employment opportunities. Transportation remains a key barrier, but design matters: Stand-alone supports were seen as more effective than folding transportation into services. Remote delivery and assistive technology are emerging supports with potential, but their impact depends on how they connect to employment outcomes.

What's Next?

Findings from this Delphi process will be used to develop guidelines for state IDD agencies and Medicaid authorities. These guidelines will provide evidence-based strategies for structuring HCBS waivers to better support employment participation for people with IDD.

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